



DEBASISH BHADURI



SUBIR HALDER

VIOLENCE IN LALGARH CONTINUES; MAMATA BANERJEE (BELOW) WILL SEEK TO CAPITALISE ON THE POPULAR IRE AGAINST BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA (ABOVE, LEFT)



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rural strongholds are all but lost. Images of top CPI(M) leaders' houses being razed to the ground by enraged ultras send shivers down the spines of the bravest of cadres. The robust CPI(M) of yore is on the sickbed. Says Biman Bose, CPI(M) state secretary, "We could not gauge the people's mood. A section of party functionaries had started to live life king-size in tune with the neo-economic and consumerist model."

The signs of the Left losing its grip first surfaced with the Nandigram land acquisition fiasco in 2007. In the police firing that followed, 14 people were

killed, triggering a series of catastrophes. Then came Singur and the pull-out by the Tatas. Adding fuel to the raging fire was the CPI(M)'s humiliation in the Lok Sabha elections in which the Mamata Banerjee-led Congress-Trinamool Congress combine got 20 of the 42 seats. Five years ago, the Trinamool had won a solitary seat. The turnaround was as much inspiring and encouraging for Banerjee as it was demoralising for the CPI(M), which got only nine seats this time.

Worse was yet to come. When Cyclone Aila hit the east coast on May

25, Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya was groping in the dark. Banerjee promptly hijacked what was his and ensured fast relief to affected areas. Bhattacharya faced angry mobs while Banerjee's Central ministers were garlanded wherever they distributed relief. The CPI(M)'s cup of shame was overflowing.

But nothing has damaged the Left as Lalgarh has, spiralling into a national issue in no time. As late as June, the state Government realised that forces had to be sent to the area occupied by Maoists, banned everywhere

bad news to worse as it enters its 33rd year of unbroken rule in West Bengal.